

Danish Labour Market Dynamics

An analysis of wage and
employment trends across Danish
industries, 2013-2024

Danmarks Statistik (LONS40, RAS300) • Oliwier Ferenc • August 2026

Mapping Danish labour market growth and challenging assumptions

Case context and approach – methodology

Problem statement:

Which Danish industries are experiencing the strongest labour market growth – and does the data challenge conventional assumptions about which sectors are leading?

Data & Scope:

- Two Danmarks Statistik datasets with data pulled live via API:
 - Hourly earnings by industry (LONS40)
 - Employment by industry (RAS300)
- Integrated to model annual payroll spend across 10 industries, 2013-2024
- Payroll = hourly wage × employees × 1,600 hrs annually (roughly 40 hours/week * 40 weeks)

How to read this deck:

Each slide surfaces one finding – moving from what is growing to highest pay versus fastest growth, to what the trajectory over time actually shows. Final slide translates findings into strategic implications for workforce planning.

Note: Industry highlights follow the four labour market profiles defined in the positioning analysis (slide 5).

Deconstructing the public narrative: four intuitions the data challenges

Case context and approach – assumptions challenged

Assumption

01

The tech-first illusion

Widespread media coverage assumes software, AI, and digital knowledge sectors drive modern labour markets.

Assumption

02

The wage-growth equivalence

It is intuitive to assume that high-wage industries are also expanding their payroll fastest – this analysis tests whether that intuition holds in Danish data.

Assumption

03

The “old economy” fallacy

Sectors like Manufacturing perceived as belonging to Denmark’s industrial past rather than its economic future, overshadowed by green energy and digital narratives.

Assumption

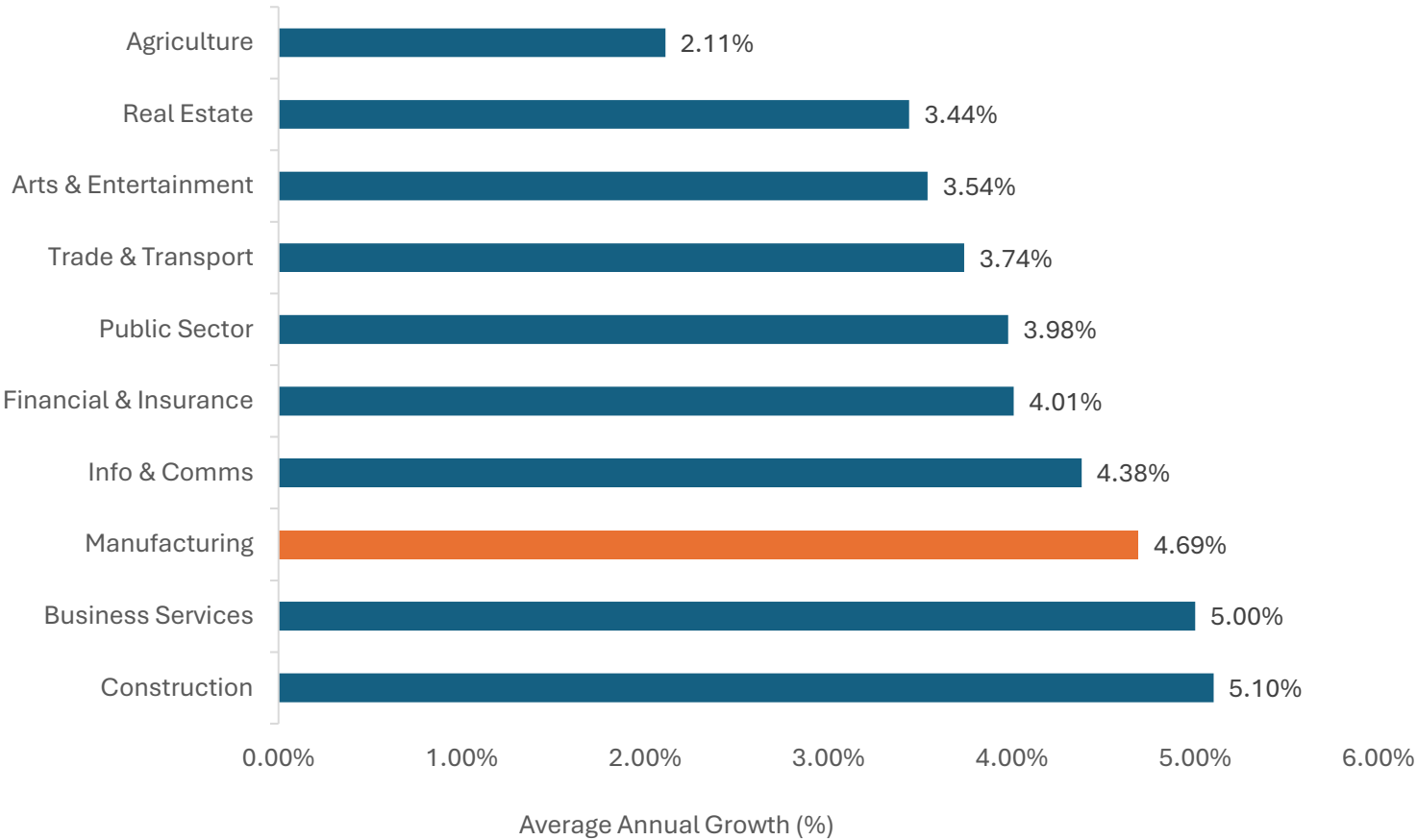
04

The absolute size myth

Payroll dominance is a natural proxy for payroll momentum – Denmark’s largest employer by payroll spend is assumed to also be its most dynamic.

Heavy sectors like Manufacturing outpace traditional Tech & Finance expectations

Average annual payroll growth by industry, 2013-2024 (%)



Reading the chart

Construction and Business Services lead long-term payroll expenditure growth at **5.10%** and **5.00%**, driven by high project-based demand.

Manufacturing climbs at **4.69%**, outpacing software-driven knowledge sectors such as Info & Comms (4.38%).

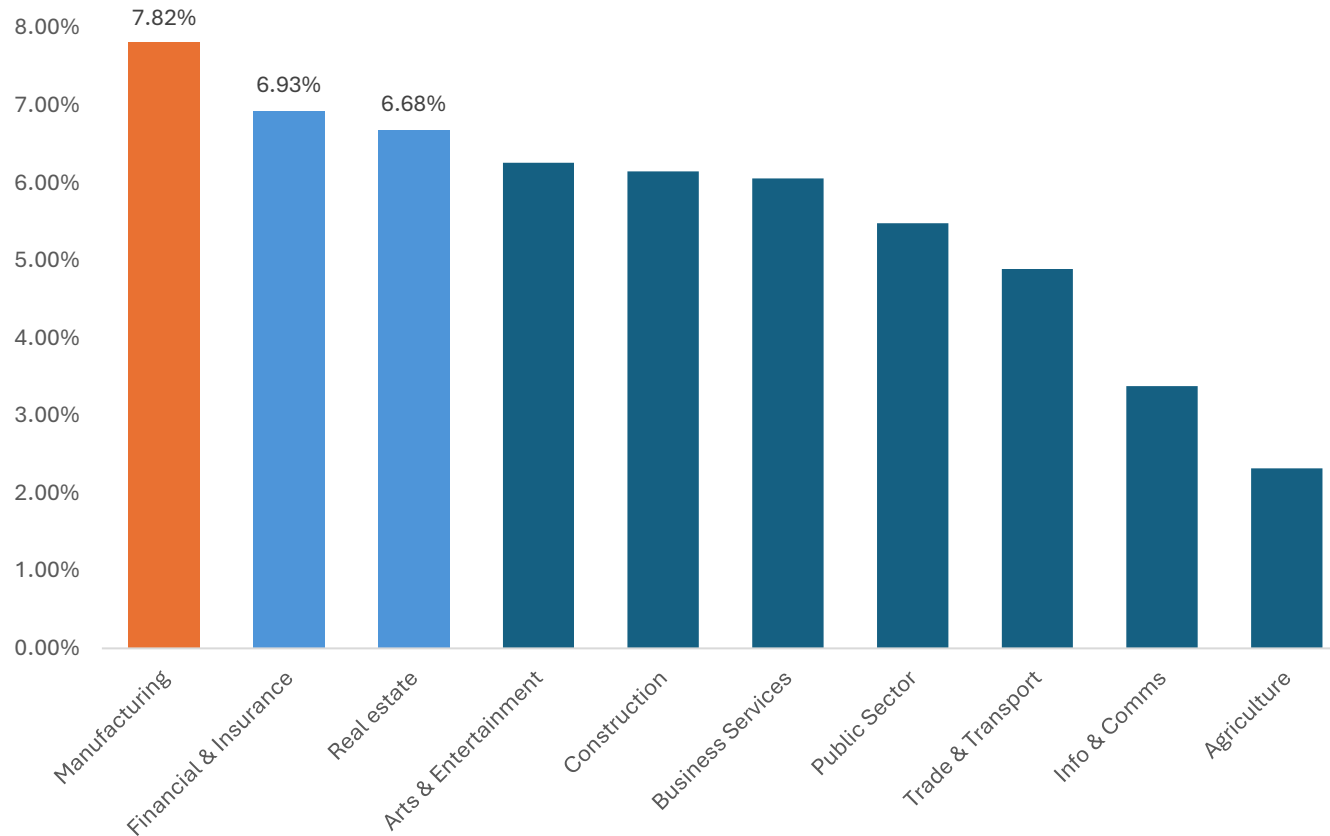
Financial & Insurance sits lower at **4.01%**, indicating that capital-light industries are expanding payrolls more conservatively.

Key takeaway: Structural growth is concentrated in physical infrastructure and production rather than digital services.

Source: Danmarks Statistik (LONS40 x RAS300) • Payroll growth = average annual rate 2013-2024 • Excludes industry aggregate

Manufacturing has quietly become Denmark's fastest-growing payroll sector

Annual payroll growth by industry, 2024 Snapshot (%)



At a glance

Manufacturing leads:

Manufacturing takes the #1 position at **7.82%**, driving a wider surge alongside Financial and Real estate payrolls.

The finance and property rally:

Financial & Insurance (6.93%) and **Real Estate** (6.68%) jump straight into the upper tier in the recent years, reversing their historical positions.

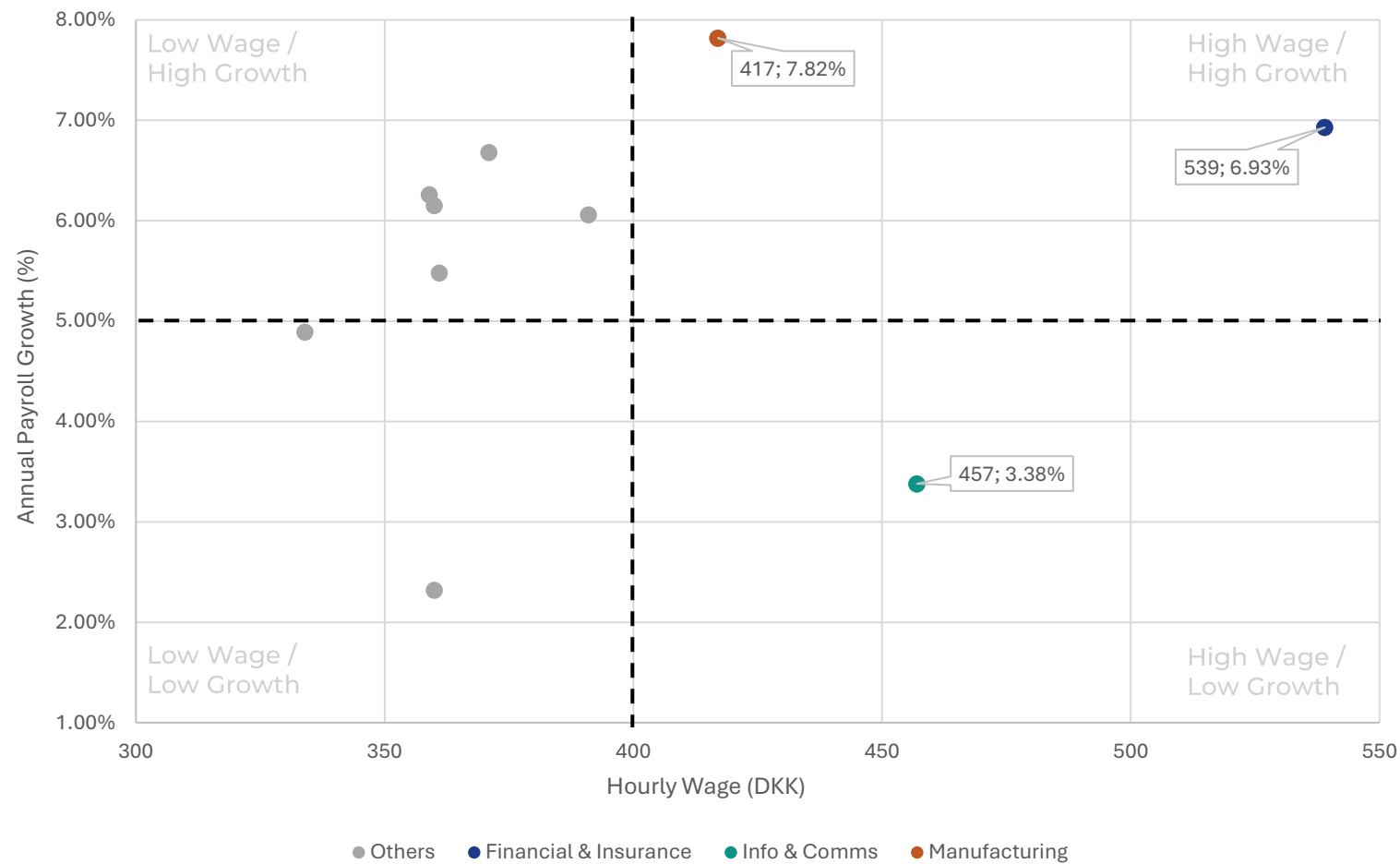
Broader economic impact:

The 2024 data reveals that labour expansion is heavily anchored in capital-intensive fields rather than digital or service-oriented sectors.

The same pattern follows: Asset-backed industries are driving labour growth, rewriting expectations of what sectors lead in the modern Danish economy.

Labour market positioning – high wages don’t always predict high growth

Hourly wage (DKK) vs annual payroll growth (%) by industry, Snapshot 2024 · Reference lines at median wage (400 DKK) and median growth (5%)



What this tells us

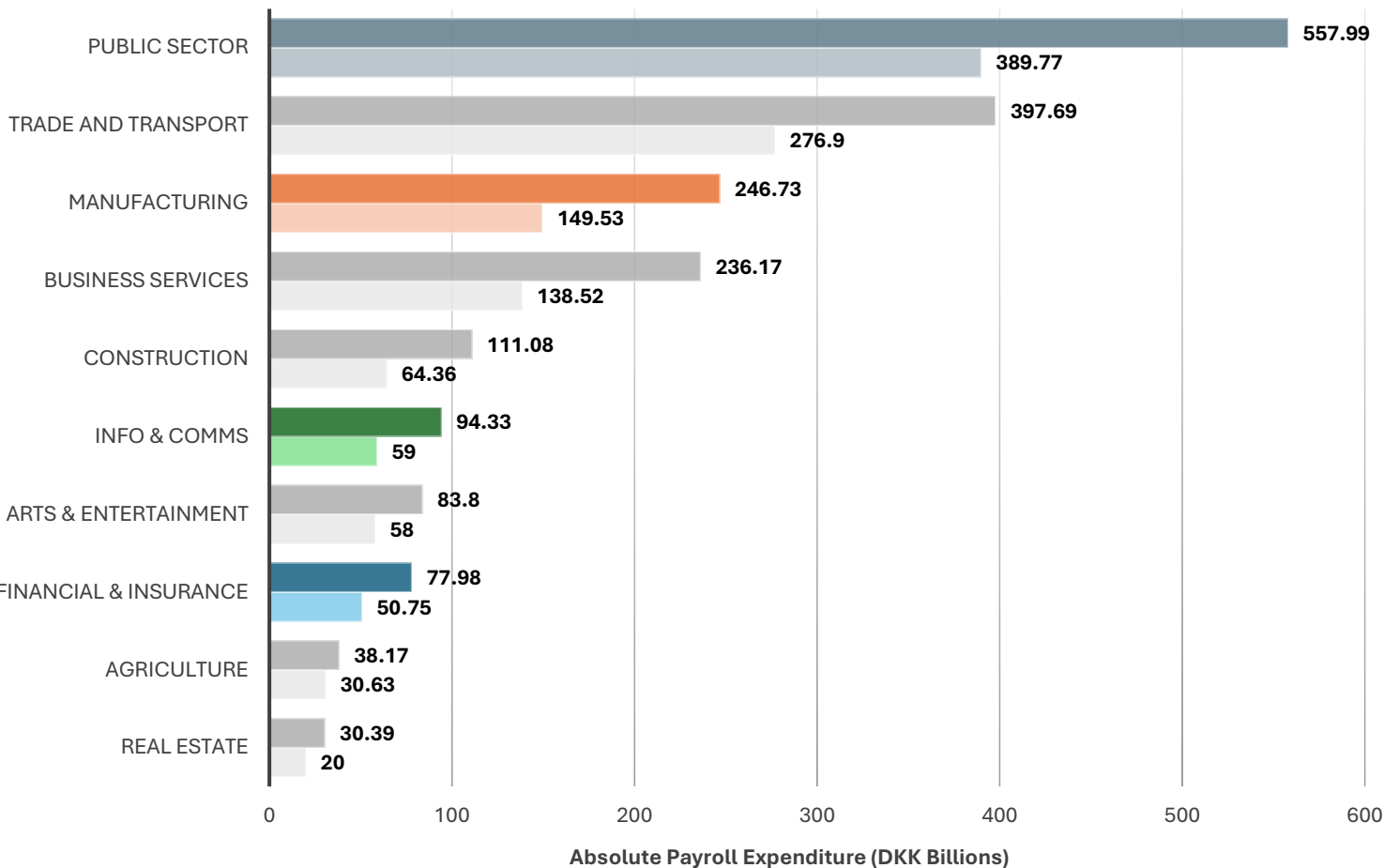
- Manufacturing – top right**
417 DKK/hr, 7.82% growth, 369,716 employees – the only sector combining both wage strength, payroll momentum and large-scale employment.
- Financial & Insurance – top right**
539 DKK/hr and 6.93% growth – same quadrant, opposite strategy, with premium compensation concentrated in a small workforce (90,420).
- Info & Comms – bottom right (alone)**
457 DKK/hr, but only 3.38% growth – digital talent is well-compensated but not expanding.
- Others – left quadrants**
Lower wages, but varied growth.

Industry	Employees	Hourly Wage (DKK)	Annual Growth (%)
Financial & Insurance	90,420	539	6.93%
Info & Comms	129,007	457	3.38%
Manufacturing	369,716	417	7.82%

Source: Danmarks Statistik (LONS40 x RAS300) · 2024 data · Excludes industry aggregate

Public Sector dominates Danish payroll – but Manufacturing grew by nearly two-thirds since 2013

Total annual payroll expenditure by industry, 2013 vs 2024 (DKK Billions) ·
Solid bar = 2024 · Tinted bar = 2013



11 years of absolute growth

Manufacturing – Biggest proportional mover
150B -> 247B DKK (+65%). Grew by nearly **2/3** of its starting baseline, leading in expansion speed across its relatives.

Public Sector – Dominant but decelerating
390B -> 558B DKK (+43%). Slow-expanding sector at a massive baseline (390B). Generated largest structural increase at **+168B DKK**.

Info & Comms – Strong relative
59B -> 94B DKK (+60%). Solid growth above group average but a smaller sector – absolute gain is modest compared to its relatives.

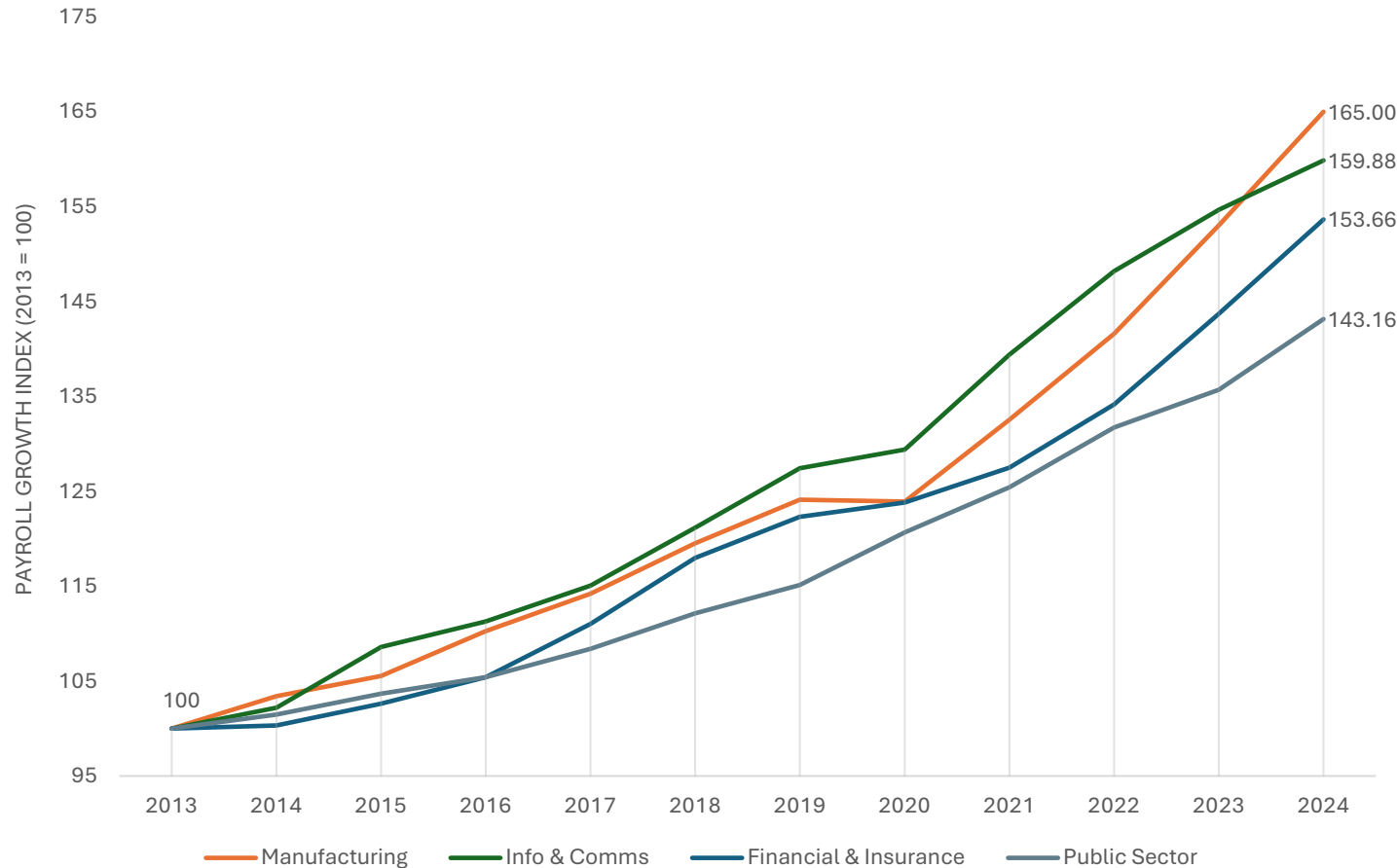
Financial & Insurance – Steady performer
51B -> 78B DKK (+53%). Although the growth is robust in isolation, it represents steady, expected benchmark expansion.

Note: Payroll and growth data rounded to nearest full number/percentage

Source: Danmarks Statistik (LONS40 x RAS300) · Calculated as: hourly wage × employees × 1,600 hrs

Indexed growth confirms Manufacturing's acceleration – expected leaders fall behind

Payroll growth index by industry • 2013 = 100 • Higher value = faster growth relative to its own baseline



Reading the index

Manufacturing – 165

The steepest trajectory. Accelerating consistently since 2016 and pulling ahead of the comparison industries by 2024

Financial & Insurance – 154

Strong growth despite being the smallest major sector. Trajectory moderate in comparison with Manufacturing.

Info & Comms – 160

Strong growth until 2021, then decelerating noticeably as post-pandemic tech hiring stabilised.

Public Sector – 143

The flattest trajectory despite large workforce, differentiating between scale and momentum.

Note: The index removes the size advantage – Public Sector's 558B DKK payroll no longer dominates visually.

The bottleneck is assumption, not data

Synthesis and implications for workforce strategy – for organizations making hiring, compensation, or investment decisions in the Danish market, three implications stand out:

Implication 1

Don't overlook manufacturing talent as a competitor

With the fastest payroll growth and above-average wages, advanced manufacturing is actively competing for skilled labour, particularly in engineering, operations, and data-driven production roles.

Organizations in adjacent sectors should expect increasing wage pressure from this direction.

Implication 2

Financial services sets the wage benchmark for high-skill talent

At 539 DKK/hr, Financial & Insurance defines the upper boundary of labour market compensation.

Any organization competing for quantitative, analytical, or strategic talent is implicitly competing against this benchmark whether they recognize it or not.

Implication 3

Tech hiring in Denmark is a quality game

Slow headcount growth in Information & Communication despite high wages suggests Danish tech employers are selective rather than expensive.

Organizations looking to hire from this talent pool should expect strong candidates but a limited supply of available movers at any given time.

Key takeaway: Conventional assumptions understate the payroll momentum in manufacturing and construction, shifting where the real talent competition lies.

APPENDICES

Appendix 1 – Payroll Trends (Absolute)

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N
1	Annual Payroll Expenditure by Industry - Denmark 2013-2024 (DKK Billions)													
2	Source: Danmarks Statistik (LONS40 x RAS300) · Calculated as: hourly wage × employees × 1,600 hrs													
3	Industry (full)	Short Label	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
4	1 Agriculture, forestry and fishing	Agriculture	30.63	30.64	30.92	31.77	31.71	34.03	35.04	34.76	34.66	37.12	37.31	38.17
5	2 Manufacturing, mining and quarrying, and utility services	Manufacturing	149.53	154.65	157.83	164.9	170.77	178.71	185.61	185.3	198.2	211.78	228.83	246.73
6	3 Construction	Construction	64.36	67.4	71.49	74.48	79.41	84.68	85.9	89.77	97.3	100.99	104.65	111.08
7	4 Trade and transport etc.	Trade and Transport	276.9	282.76	292.22	296.61	306.94	321.42	331.19	325.7	349.38	364.9	379.14	397.69
8	5 Information and communication	Info & Comms	59	60.3	64.08	65.66	67.89	71.49	75.18	76.35	82.26	87.44	91.25	94.33
9	6 Financial and insurance	Financial & Insurance	50.75	50.92	52.09	53.49	56.35	59.87	62.08	62.85	64.71	68.09	72.93	77.98
10	7 Real estate	Real estate	20	20.68	21.32	21.92	22.81	23.98	25.01	25.51	26.9	27.55	28.49	30.39
11	8 Other business services	Business Services	138.52	144.19	150.76	156.96	164.32	174.15	176.32	177.58	191.81	208.13	222.68	236.17
12	9 Public administration, education and health	Public Sector	389.77	395.58	404.13	410.83	422.49	437.04	448.73	470.32	488.89	513.5	528.99	557.99
13	10 Arts, entertainment and recreation activities	Arts & Entertainment	58	58.03	58.28	60.32	62.93	66.11	68.4	67.74	70.76	74.67	78.86	83.8
14														
15	· Manufacturing highlighted — fastest-growing sector at 7.82% average annual payroll growth													
16														
17														

Appendix 2 – Payroll Indexed

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M
1	Payroll Growth Index by Industry - Denmark 2013-2024, (2013 = 100)												
2	Source: Danmarks Statistik (LONS40 x RAS300) • All industries indexed to 100 in 2013 • Higher value = faster payroll growth												
3	Short Label	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
4	Agriculture	100	100.03	100.95	103.72	103.53	111.10	114.40	113.48	113.16	121.19	121.81	124.62
5	Manufacturing	100	103.42	105.55	110.28	114.20	119.51	124.13	123.92	132.55	141.63	153.03	165.00
6	Construction	100	104.72	111.08	115.72	123.38	131.57	133.47	139.48	151.18	156.91	162.60	172.59
7	Trade and Transport	100	102.12	105.53	107.12	110.85	116.08	119.61	117.62	126.18	131.78	136.92	143.62
8	Info & Comms	100	102.20	108.61	111.29	115.07	121.17	127.42	129.41	139.42	148.20	154.66	159.88
9	Financial & Insurance	100	100.33	102.64	105.40	111.03	117.97	122.33	123.84	127.51	134.17	143.70	153.66
10	Real estate	100	103.40	106.60	109.60	114.05	119.90	125.05	127.55	134.50	137.75	142.45	151.95
11	Business Services	100	104.09	108.84	113.31	118.63	125.72	127.29	128.20	138.47	150.25	160.76	170.50
12	Public Sector	100	101.49	103.68	105.40	108.39	112.13	115.13	120.67	125.43	131.74	135.72	143.16
13	Arts & Entertainment	100	100.05	100.48	104.00	108.50	113.98	117.93	116.79	122.00	128.74	135.97	144.48

Appendix 3 – 2024 Snapshot

	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	Industry Snapshot - Denmark 2024					
2	Ranked by hourly wage (highest to lowest) · Source: Danmarks Statistik					
3	Industry	Short Label	Hourly Wage (DKK)	Employees	Total Payroll (DKK B)	Annual Growth (%)
4	6 Financial and insurance	Financial & Insurance	539	90,420	77.98	6.93%
5	5 Information and communication	Info & Comms	457	129,007	94.33	3.38%
6	2 Manufacturing, mining and quarrying, and utility services	Manufacturing	417	369,716	246.73	7.82%
7	8 Other business services	Business Services	391	377,824	236.17	6.06%
8	7 Real estate	Real estate	371	51,153	30.39	6.68%
9	9 Public administration, education and health	Public Sector	361	966,716	557.99	5.48%
10	1 Agriculture, forestry and fishing	Agriculture	360	66,344	38.17	2.32%
11	3 Construction	Construction	360	192,756	111.08	6.15%
12	10 Arts, entertainment and recreation activities	Arts & Entertainment	359	146,058	83.8	6.26%
13	4 Trade and transport etc.	Trade & Transport	334	743,181	397.69	4.89%
14						

Appendix 4 – Growth Rates

	A	B	C
1	Average Annual Payroll Growth by Industry - 2013 to 2024		
2	Ranked highest to lowest • Source: Danmarks Statistik		
3	Industry	Short Label	Avg Annual Growth (%)
4	3 Construction	Construction	5.10%
5	8 Other business services	Business Services	5.00%
6	2 Manufacturing, mining and quarrying, and utility services	Manufacturing	4.69%
7	5 Information and communication	Info & Comms	4.38%
8	6 Financial and insurance	Financial & Insurance	4.01%
9	9 Public administration, education and health	Public Sector	3.98%
10	4 Trade and transport etc.	Trade & Transport	3.74%
11	10 Arts, entertainment and recreation activities	Arts & Entertainment	3.54%
12	7 Real estate	Real Estate	3.44%
13	1 Agriculture, forestry and fishing	Agriculture	2.11%
14			